How to Get Strong - A Program for Beginners

By Ian Ramirez, Cypress Training Center

Program Level: Beginner (0-6 months training experience)
Duration: 4 weeks
Frequency: 3 days per week (Monday, Wednesday, Friday recommended)
Goal: Build strength foundation with the Big 5 compound movements

Program Note: This is the Starting Strength program by Mark Rippetoe, with one change: I swap deadlifts for bent over rows on Day A. From training clients in the real world, I've found this to be the most effective way for beginners to build strength.

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Program Overview

This is a program that is guaranteed to get you stronger, while helping you master the most important strength training exercises:

- Squat
- Deadlift
- Bench Press
- Overhead Press
- Barbell Row

Why these movements?
They train the most muscle mass in the shortest time. Master these five and you'll have a strength foundation that transfers to everything else.

What makes this different from other beginner programs?

- Simple progression (add weight every session)
- Just 3 days per week (recovery built in)
- No fluff (no curls, ab work, or fancy accessories until you earn them)

Who Is This For?

This program is for you if:

- You're new to strength training (0-6 months experience)
- You have access to a barbell and power rack
- You can train 3 days per week consistently
- You want to get stronger, build muscle, and learn proper form

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Equipment Needed

Minimum:

- Barbell
- Power rack or squat stands
- Bench (flat or adjustable)

- Plates (25s, 10s, 5s, 2.5s)

The Training Schedule

3 days per week:

- **Day A:** Squat, Bench, Row
- **Day B:** Squat, Overhead Press, Deadlift

Sample Week:

- Monday: Day A
- Wednesday: Day B
- Friday: Day A

Next Week:

- Monday: Day B
- Wednesday: Day A
- Friday: Day B

Alternate A/B every session. That's it.

Week 1-4 Workouts

Day A: Squat, Bench, Row

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Rest
Back Squat	3 x 5	3 min
Bench Press	3 x 5	3 min
Barbell Row	3 x 5	3 min

Day B: Squat, Overhead Press, Deadlift

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Rest
Back Squat	3 x 5	3 min
Overhead Press	3 x 5	3 min
Deadlift	1 x 5	3 min

Why only 1 set of deadlifts?
Deadlifts are brutal. One heavy set is enough for beginners. You're also squatting 3x per week, which hits similar muscles.

Progression Rules

Week 1: Find Your Starting Weights

Your first week is about finding weights you can lift with clean form for 3 sets of 5 reps, leaving 1-2 reps in the tank.

Rule:

- **If your last rep looks slow but clean** → that's perfect.
- **If your form breaks down** → it's too heavy.
- **If it feels easy** → it's too light.

Weeks 2-4: Linear Progression

Add weight every session:

- **Lower body (squat, deadlift):** +10 lbs per session
- **Upper body (bench, press, row):** +5 lbs per session

Critical Rule: Perfect reps > adding weight.

What if I fail a set?

If you can't complete all 3 sets of 5 reps:

1. **First time:** Repeat the same weight next session
2. **Second time in a row:** Drop 10% and rebuild

Example:

- Session 5: 185 lbs squat — only got 5, 5, 4 reps (failed last set)
- Session 6: Repeat 185 lbs — got 5, 5, 5 (success)
- Session 7: Add 5 lbs (instead of 10) → 190 lbs

Don't rush the progression. Slow and steady wins.

Warm-Up Protocol

General Warm-Up (5 minutes):

- Light cardio (bike, row, jog) to break a sweat
- Dynamic stretches (leg swings, arm circles, cat-cow)

Lift-Specific Warm-Up:

For Squat/Deadlift:

- Bar x 10 reps
- 95 lbs x 5 reps
- 135 lbs x 3 reps
- Add weight until you hit your working weight

For Bench/Press/Row:

- Bar x 10 reps
- 65 lbs x 5 reps
- Add weight until you hit your working weight

Rule of thumb: Do 2-4 warm-up sets, increasing weight each time. Never go to failure on warm-ups.

FAQs

1. Can I add more exercises?

Not yet. Master the Big 5 first. After 8-12 weeks, we can add accessories (curls, tricep work, ab training).

2. What about cardio?

2-3 sessions per week, 20-30 minutes, easy pace (Zone 2). Don't run a 10K the day before squats.

3. How much should I eat?

To build muscle: Eat in a slight surplus (200-300 calories above maintenance)
To lose fat: Eat in a slight deficit (200-300 calories below maintenance)
To maintain: Eat at maintenance

Prioritize protein: 0.8-1g per lb of bodyweight.

4. Do I need supplements?

No. Eat enough protein, sleep 7-9 hours, stay hydrated. Supplements are 5% of the equation.

If you want to supplement:

- **Creatine** (5g/day) — proven to help strength and recovery
- **Protein powder** — convenient way to hit protein targets
- **Caffeine** — pre-workout if you need energy

5. What if I miss a workout?

Life happens. Just pick up where you left off. Don't try to "make up" missed workouts by doubling up.

6. Can I train 4 or 5 days per week?

You can, but you don't need to. More isn't always better. Stick with 3 days for the first 12 weeks. Add volume when progress stalls.

7. My lower back is sore after squats/deadlifts. Is that normal?

Some soreness is normal. Sharp pain or pain that doesn't go away is not. Check your form. Film yourself. Email me if you're unsure.

After Week 4: What's Next?

If you completed all 4 weeks and made progress:
Continue with the same program for another 4-8 weeks. Linear progression works until it doesn't.

If you're stalling:

- Check your sleep (are you getting 7-9 hours?)

- Check your nutrition (are you eating enough?)
- Check your form (film your lifts, compare to the Form Guide)

If you're crushing it and want more volume:
Email me at ian@cypresstrainingcenter.com. I'll send you the next program (Intermediate 4-Day Split).

Final Thoughts

This program is simple. It's not fancy. It doesn't have drop sets, supersets, or Instagram-friendly circuits.

But it works.

Show up 3x per week. Add weight when you can. Eat and sleep enough.

Do that for 12 weeks and you'll be stronger than 90% of people in your gym.

Questions? Email me at ian@cypresstrainingcenter.com

Let's get to work.

— Ian Ramirez
Cypress Training Center

Resources:

- Exercise Form Guide — Detailed breakdowns of every movement
- How to Start Strength Training — Complete beginner's guide
- 5 Form Mistakes Killing Your Gains — Fix your technique

Sign up at cypresstraining.com for weekly training tips and free resources.

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